
The World Cup Tragedy You Don't Understand Until It Happens to You

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Even on the 70-minute bus trip from Cambridge to Boston Stadium on Thursday morning, I didn't know which side I'd be cheering for in what ended up being a dominant 2–0 victory by France over Morocco in the World Cup quarterfinals. I'd returned to the United States from a [family vacation gone wrong in overheated France](#) only 24 hours earlier, and I was in Boston to watch my two home countries, France and Morocco, compete for a place in the semifinals. If Kylian Mbappé of France scored a golazo in the opening minutes, I expected I'd erupt with much of the stadium. If Brahim Díaz of Morocco set up an Azzedine Ounahi equalizer in injury time, I might even be happier. If either team lost or won in a heartbreaking penalty shoot-out scenario, I wasn't sure how I'd feel.

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As it went, France controlled every aspect of the game for 90 minutes, achieving the breakthrough on the hour mark thanks to a wonder strike just inside the net from all-time great Mbappé, who now shares the lead for tournament goals with eight so far. The current Ballon d'Or winner, Ousmane Dembélé, added a second strike less than seven minutes later, sliding one past Morocco's star keeper Yassine Bounou, who had been superb until that point.

It was all good fun, but my happiness and watching this sublime French team reach the World Cup semifinals was tinged with sadness for Morocco, whose fans had come out in force and dominated the very happy atmosphere at Foxborough stadium. I had these mixed feelings all game.



Aymann Ismail

Ultimately, Thursday's match was a much-needed palate cleanser for a World Cup in which the vibes [have been through the roof](#) right up until last week, when they went into the toilet. Beginning on Saturday, with Paraguay's [slimy tactics](#) and [poor sportsmanship](#) against a far-superior French team, things at the Coupe du Monde began to royally stink. Afterward, a Paraguayan senator named Celeste Amarilla attacked the France captain and second-all-time-leading World Cup scorer, Mbappé, in some of the [most racist terms possible](#). The whole country, including [President Emmanuel Macron](#), seemed to rally around its superstar. (French prosecutors even appeared determined to charge Amarilla with the [crime of racist abuse](#).) Mbappé came through for all of them again, on Thursday, winning the man of the match.

If all that weren't enough, lest you forget, last week was also when President Donald Trump [embarrassed the host nation](#) by getting FIFA to cheat on behalf of the U.S. men's national team only for that team to embarrass itself by playing about as poorly as possible in a knockout-round match. The stink continued the next day, as some very [shady refereeing](#) cost Egypt a chance at one of the biggest upsets in World Cup history against Argentina.

All in all, fans desperately needed something good. France and Morocco provided: a legitimate rivalry between two of the top soccer nations in the world, each with a deeply intertwined and fraught history, playing against each other at the highest possible level. It was near perfect, even for those of us who were torn about the result.

I thought my personal plight would be not an uncommon one here. I found, weirdly, at this game at least, that every fan I saw or spoke with was in one corner or another. That didn't stop the two fanbases from sharing a friendly appreciation for each other, which makes some sense. France is home to the largest Moroccan diaspora in the world, with around 1.5 million Moroccan descendants in a country of 69 million. Although no players who identify as Moroccan play for this French team, six Morocco players were born in France. This isn't the least bit unusual in this World Cup, at which nearly a quarter of all players represent countries outside their birthplace. France is by far the biggest supplier of that exported talent.



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Much [has been written](#) of France's reach at this World Cup. The players born in France could field nearly four teams and nine full squads. The question of dual nationals or players with mixed family heritage having a multitude of national teams to choose from have become a fixture of the sport, with France and Morocco claiming players from both immigrant and diaspora communities as their own.

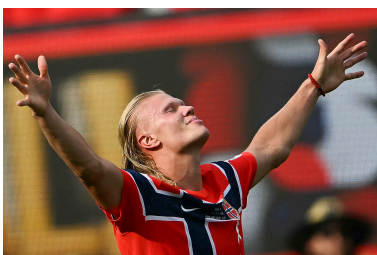
Sometimes I imagine my kids as international soccer superstars and daydream about which country they might represent. Since the 2022 World Cup, when Morocco finished fourth, I've added the country to that list. It's strange, because I've been a Morocco fan in a way for some 20 years—the first professional soccer kit I ever bought was at a souk in Marrakech in the mid-2000s. The only two soccer jerseys I still own, in fact, are that Jaouad Zairi kit and a France Mbappé jersey. Again, this was not a problem for the crowd at Foxborough. I met three tween cousins, two in Mbappé France kits and one in an Achraf Hakimi Morocco kit. I asked them how they had picked their respective teams, despite being family. One told me he liked the players. “He just likes Mbappé,” the cousin in the Hakimi jersey interjected. The Hakimi fan said he was supporting Morocco “because I am supporting our Middle Eastern brothers.”

None of this helped me decide. Some of my own cousins, clad in France jerseys, called me from Nice at halftime. I could tell they would be devastated if France lost. Maybe my situation was unique—or unique to my immediate family. My brother texted midmatch to ask the family text chain, “Are we rooting for Morocco or France?” Nobody answered.

Before the game, I thought that some genealogical research might help with my quandary. My family's roots in Morocco go back centuries. Parts of my grandmother's family apparently migrated there from Spain during the Spanish Inquisition in 1492. My grandfather's roots in Morocco go back even further, with the Bensabaths moving to the Maghreb from the Levant at some point way down the line and living there for centuries. (This family oral history all *seems* to be confirmed by a personal genetic test—33 percent western Asian and northern African, including 14 percent Moroccan and 8 percent [Levantine](#)—depending on how reliable you find those to be.)

Morocco was a French protectorate from 1912 to 1956, and during World War II, King Mohammed V is said to have done all that he could to protect Moroccan Jews from Vichy laws that would have seen them meet the same fate as French Jews. A few weeks before Vichy asserted its rule over the Moroccan king and would make those deportations a reality, the Americans started bombing. They defeated the Germans and took control of the territory but in the process bombed the Ettegui Synagogue, above which, we believe, several of my family members were living. Only a small number of combatants and a handful of civilians were killed in the [Battle of Casablanca](#); three of those civilians were said to be my great-great-aunt and two of her children. The rest of the family was saved from the gas chambers.

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Following the establishment of the state of Israel, many Jews fled countries in the Middle East and North Africa. My family decided to leave in 1954, three years after my mother was born, even if Morocco was still quite friendly to Jewish people. They were meant to go to Paris, but my mother caught measles on the journey across the sea. When the family arrived in France, doctors advised them to stay in the south for her health instead of traveling all the way to Paris. They did, and that's where much of our family still lives today.

Again, that part of the family was psyched for this French team, which has the chance to truly be one of the greatest of all time. I didn't think anyone was experiencing any of the same conflict I was. For me, having grown up in the United States and having lived only briefly in France, it's a bit more complicated.

At the game, when I see how dominant the Morocco crowd is—hollering, whistling, singing along with the French pop music at much louder volume and much more spiritedly than the France fans—they win me over right away. I start to cheer whenever there's a slightly nice run by a Moroccan player. I get annoyed at the French reporter making snide commentary about every play directly behind me. I am not at all disappointed when Mbappé takes one of the meekest penalties I've ever seen in the first half and Bono easily traps it in his arms. Adrien Rabiot has a beautiful run and a clean attempt on goal, and again it is saved. The moment before the kick, I feel eagerness for him to score, then relief that he doesn't. I smile and mutter a sort of French-sounding “ohohoho.”





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“What kind of shit clear was that?” the French reporter whines at one point. I start to cheer harder for Morocco. At halftime, I see a fan wearing a “Keep Calm and Watch Morocco Win” shirt and my support grows.

Then, at the hour mark, Mbappé scores his breakthrough, and it is a masterpiece. My feeling is one of joy at having seen one of the greats of the game score a goal in a World Cup quarterfinal for *my team*. I start to absorb the disappointment of the Moroccan crowd, though, and return to that track. At that point, though, France’s dominance in possession feels as if it could be deadly. I tell a colleague that this is getting dangerous for Morocco—it seems that the team might be about to crack. I also note that France is an ridiculously strong front-running team. Minutes later, Dembélé scores the second. The crowd is deflated, and it appears all but over. A couple of very young children, a little bit older than my own, both wearing Morocco kits, begin to cry two rows down from us.

It’s very sad—but not that sad for me. As the game ends, a big smile creeps across my face. I just watched France win a World Cup quarterfinal after playing a beautiful game, its two stars scoring goals I don’t think I’ll ever forget. I will be rooting for this team every moment the rest of the way. Still, had it gone the other way, I know I’d be writing the same thing about Morocco.

I guess my team won.

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